

Kadesh כַּדֶּשׁ

The beginning of all journeys is separation. You've got to leave somewhere to go somewhere else. It is also the first step towards freedom: You ignore the voice of Pharaoh inside that mocks you, saying, "Who are you to begin such a journey?" You just get up and walk out.

This is the first meaning of the word, "Kadesh" ~ to *transcend* the mundane world. Then comes the second meaning: Once you've set yourself free from your material worries, you can return and *sanctify* them. That is when true spiritual freedom begins, when you introduce a higher purpose into all those things you do.

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Urchatz וּרְחַצְתָּ

Our hands are the primary tools to interact with our environment. They generally obey our emotions: Love, fear, compassion, the urge to win, to be appreciated, to express ourselves, to dominate. Our emotions, in turn, reflect our mental state.

But, too often, each faculty of our psyche sits in its cell, exiled from one another. The mind sees one way, the heart feels another and our interface with the world ends up one messy tzimmes.

Water represents the healing power of wisdom. Water flows downward, carrying its essential simplicity to each thing. It brings them together as a single living, growing whole. We pour water over our hands as an expression of wisdom pouring downward passing through our heart and from there to our interaction with the world around us.

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Karpas כרפס

We need to re-taste the breaking labor of Egypt to liberate ourselves from it once again. It was this labor that prepared us for freedom. It was this labor that gave us a humble spirit to accept wisdom.

Today, as well, you can choose to achieve this humble spirit by enduring the battle to survive the rat race. There will be plenty of futile, hamster-wheel tasks to bring you to your knees.

Or you could choose another path: achieving true humility with the realization of just how small we earthly creatures are. That will free you from the need to experience materialistic futility.

Choose your battle. It's up to you.

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מגיד תגיד

The exodus was not simply an event that happened to us. It is an event that we became. It is who we are. It is the life of each one of us, occurring again and again, in our wrestling match with the world, in our struggle with our own selves. We embody freedom in a constant mode of escape. Perhaps that is why Jews have always been the rebels of society, the ones who think out of the box. The experience of leaving Egypt left such an indelible mark on our souls, we never stopped doing it. A Jew who has stopped exiting Egypt has ceased to allow his soul to breathe.

To tell the story is to bring that essential self into the open, to come face to face with who we really are and resuscitate it back to life.

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Rachtza רחצה

As long as we live in this world, freedom remains elusive: While moving forward, we are free. Stop, and we are bound and fettered again.

That is why freedom is something you cannot buy nor steal. Never can you put freedom in your purse and say, "Freedom is mine forever!"

For freedom is a marriage: Freedom is the bond our finite selves with the Infinite, the power to transcend the world while working inside it. It is a marriage of heaven and earth, spirit and matter, soul and body. And like any marriage, it is kept alive only by constant renewal. Like the miracle of the splitting of the Red Sea, suspended in its state of paradox by a continuous, other-worldly force. Yet, in our exodus, we were granted eternal freedom. Not because we were released from slavery. But because we were given the power to perpetually transcend.

That's the order of the Seder tonight: *Kadesh/Urchatz*, Transcend and Purify. Over and over. Rise higher, then draw that into deeds. Rise higher again, then draw that down even more. Never stop rising higher. Never stop applying.

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Motzie ג'וציא

We feel an affinity with the food we eat: We too are a miracle out of the earth.

We and the bread share a common journey. The bread begins as a seed buried beneath the ground. And then, a miracle occurs: As it decomposes and loses its original form, it comes alive, begins to grow sprout and grow. As spring arrives, it pushes its way above the earth to find the sun, and then bears its fruits for the world.

We too began buried in Egypt, all but losing our identity. But that furnace of oppression became for us a firing kiln, a baker's oven, the womb from whence we were born in the month of spring. In our liberation from there, we brought our fruits of freedom to the world.

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Matzah מצה

Since the destruction of the Temple in Jerusalem, matzah is the only opportunity we have to actually eat a mitzvah. That's right, the matzah you are eating is pure G-dliness. In fact, it has enough G-dly energy to blast your soul out of the deepest ditch into the highest heights.

The Zohar calls matzah "Bread of Faith" and "Bread of Healing". Did I say "faith?" Well, actually, that's a rather feeble translation. "Emunah" is the word in Hebrew, and it means a lot more than "I believe, brother!" Faith can often be something people rely upon when they don't care to think too much. Emunah is when you go beyond thinking and you get somewhere your mind could have never brought you to.

Emunah is when you touch that place where your soul and the essence of the Infinite Light are one. It's a point that nothing can describe. Where there are no

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words, no doubts, no uncertainty, no confusion—nothing else but a magnificent oneness before which all the challenges of life vanish like a puff of vapor.

Eating matzah is a means of plugging your entire self into that reservoir. Your physical body digests the Emunah of your soul, everything is integrated back into one, your body and spirit are whole and harmonious.

How on earth, you may ask, can a mixture of water and wheat from the ground baked in an oven contain a spiritual cure? Well, welcome to the Jewish People, where there is no dichotomy of spirit and matter, soul and body. Where the spiritual transforms into physicality and material objects rise to become spiritual in a perpetual chemistry of exchange. Where bodies are healed by empowering the soul and souls are nourished by the rituals of the body.

After all, we live in the world of a single G-d.

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מרור מרור

What's so great about the bitterness? Why do we want to remember *that*? Actually, our bitterness in Egypt was/is the key to our redemption. We never got used to Egypt. We never felt we belonged there. We never said, "They are the masters and we are the slaves and that's the way it is." It always remained something we felt bitter about, something that was unjust and needed to change.

If it hadn't been that way, we probably would never have left. In fact, tradition tells us that 80% of the Jews said, "This is our land. How can we leave it?" And they stayed and died there.

But as for the rest of us, when Moses came and told us we were going to leave, we believed him. It was our bitterness that had preserved our faith. Everyone has his Egypt. You've got to know who you are and what are your limitations. But heaven forbid to make peace with them. The soul within you knows no limits.

This is the sweetness we apply to the bitter herb: Bitterness alone, without any direction, is self-destructive. Inject some life and optimism into it, and it becomes the springboard to freedom.

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Korech כורֶךְ

In the view from within Egypt, this world is a mess of fragments. It's called "The Passoverly Challenged Perspective." Plain materialism. Where mitzvahs are a mishmash of dos and don'ts, Jews are a collection of irreconcilable riffraff, daily life is a cacophony of hassles and, well, just stuff.

Once we blast off far enough to escape materialism's gravitational pull, we look back down and see a whole new perspective: It's all a single landscape.

From up there looking down, mitzvahs are multiple expressions of a single spiritual path, Jews are multiple faces to a single soul, all the artifacts of today's journey harmonize together as a symphony with a single conductor playing a single melody.

When we make ourselves into a temple for the Divine, the bitter, the sweet and the tasteless responsibilities of life wrap together in a single sandwich.

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When we make ourselves into a temple for the Divine, the bitter, the sweet and the tasteless responsibilities of life wrap together in a single sandwich.

Korech כורֶךְ

In the view from within Egypt, this world is a mess of fragments. It's called "The Passoverly Challenged Perspective." Plain materialism. Where mitzvahs are a mishmash of dos and don'ts, Jews are a collection of irreconcilable riffraff, daily life is a cacophony of hassles and, well, just stuff.

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Shulchan Orech שולחן עורך

This step, along with Korech before it, marks the re-entry we mentioned at the beginning. We've escaped Egypt and reached a higher vision. And then we start the process again ~ on a higher level.

Because freedom consists of more than escape. Complete freedom is when you can turn around and liberate all the elements of your world from their pure material state, and make them transcendent as well. That's what we do when we eat every day—we take foods which grow from the earth, say a blessing over them and bring them into our journey as human beings. And when it's Shabbos or another Jewish holiday, we elevate them further, into the realm of pure spirituality. As for tonight, this meal is going to be truly Divine.

So don't imagine we're just fressing now. We're reaching a higher state. And what a great way to do it!

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Tzafun תזפון

In the Kabbalah, it is explained that there is something deeper than the soul. There is the body, the spirit, and then there is the essence. If the soul is light, then that essence is the source of light. If it is energy, then the essence is the dynamo. It is called "tzafun," meaning hidden, buried, locked away and out of reach.

Whatever we do, we dance around that essence-core, like a spacecraft in orbit, unable to land. We can meditate, we can be inspired, but to touch the inner core, the place where all this comes from, that takes a power from beyond.

On Passover night, we have that power. But only after all the steps before: Destroying our personal chametz, preparing our homes for liberation, the eleven steps of the Seder until now. Then, when we are satiated with all we can handle, connecting every facet of ourselves to the Divine, that's when that power comes to us. Whether we sense it or not, tasteless as it may seem, the matzah we eat now reaches deep into our core and transforms our very being.

In general, it is this way: Those things you find inspiring and nice may take you a step forward. But if you want to effect real change, you need to do something totally beyond your personal bounds.

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Beirach בריך

The theme of grace after meals is confidence. Confidence in a Higher Force that is with us in our daily lives. With that confidence you don't just see food before you. You see a river of life travelling from Above onto your plate.

When we say this out loud, with joy and sincerity, we initiate a reciprocal current. The energy we receive is bounced back with even greater force, replenishing all the higher worlds and ethereal beings through which it passed on its way here. The channels of life are widened and their currents grow strong.

Miracles happen when Divine energy from beyond the cosmos enters within. Why did miracles happen in Egypt? Because we believed they would. Those who didn't believe in miracles saw only plagues. To see a miracle, you need an open heart and mind, open enough to receive the Infinite. That is the opening we make when we thank G-d for the miracle of our food.

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Hallel 5777

The ancient rabbis clued us in on a key principle in cosmic functions: Whatever He tells us to do, He does Himself. Of course, there's a difference: We do it in our little human world. He does it on a cosmic plane. He told us to open our door on the night of Passover. So, tonight, He opens every door and every gateway of the spiritual cosmos to every member of the Jewish People. To each one of us, regardless of what we have been doing all the rest of the year. Tonight is the chance to reach to the highest of spiritual levels. Prophecy, divine spirit, wisdom and insight—take your choice and jump a quantum leap. There's nothing stopping us.

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נִרְצָה Nirtzah

Some people think we are meant to make a perfect world. But if that is what our Creator wanted, why did He make us such imperfect beings?
Rather, what He wants of us is our very humanness. Sometimes we do good. Sometimes we fall. But we keep on struggling, and eventually we make some real change.
And then, once we have done all we can, like a kind parent helping with the homework, He makes sure to touch up the job and make it shine.
For 3300 years we have been leaving Egypt. For 3300 years we have been doing our human job of transforming the darkness of His world into light.
And now it is His turn to lift us up, to banish the darkness forever, to make our work shine.

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